classes, and by 1908, an estimated 5,364 third class carriages had them, after which it slowly became the norm. [106]

This remains the factual timeline. However, whenever the subject of toilets on trains comes up for discussion, I am reminded of a legend about a letter purportedly written by an irate passenger suffering on account of the premature departure of a train. The letter is claimed to have been written around 1909 (a precise date of 2 July 1909 is also sometimes claimed), addressed to the Transportation Superintendent of the Divisional Office of the East Indian Railway at Sahibganj, West Bengal.

The letter is said to have been discovered in railway records in West Bengal, or in the Railway Board's archives in New Delhi. It is very likely that this letter is fictitious (not to mention the terrible language, even if it was reproduced in an official publication).

The letter is on display at the National Rail Museum, New Delhi.

> Dear Sir,
>
> I am arrive by passenger train Ahmedpur station and my belly is too much swelling with jackfruit. I am therefore went to privy. Just I doing the nuisance that guard making whistle blow for train to go off and I am running with lotah in one hand and dhoti in the next when I am fall over and expose all my shocking to man and female women on plateform. I am got leaved at Ahmedpur station.
>
> This too much bad, if passenger go to make dung that dam guard not wait train minutes for him. I am therefore pray your honour to make big fine on that guard for public sake. Otherwise I am making big report to papers. [107]
>
> Your faithful servant,
> Okhil Chandra Se n

PASSENGER ENCOUNTERS: BRITISH VERSUS INDIAN

Passengers travelling in different classes of carriage experienced vastly different ambience. Third class passengers, mostly Indians, experienced the worst travel conditions and were adversely affected by the surveillance and regulations exercised by the authorities. Complaints about travel conditions in the lower classes of trains are as old as the introduction of passenger railways in India. Indians who could afford to travel in first class too faced bitter experiences. An amusing yet bitter anecdote captures the tension perfectly.